Harish Chandra. The professor's remark incited me to work harder on the problem and learn the solution myself.

Time for my sweet revenge came a couple of months later while the Turkish professor was again working on a problem on the blackboard. Midway through an equation he paused, went back a few steps and wondered aloud: 'Where did I go wrong?'

I raised my hand. 'Can I help you?'

'Yes,' he said.

I walked up to the blackboard, and worked out the steps to arrive at the solution. Now I turned to the professor, who was gracefully taking the place of a student.

'Do you understand?' I said.

'Yes,' said the professor.

'I thought you wouldn't, because the solution came from an Indian.'

Later I introspected if I was being childish or cheap. It was my luck that I knew the solution and the class presented an opportunity for me to get back at the professor. I liked it. Later the professor became my well-wisher and came to congratulate me when I completed the master's course.

I thought I was creating a record of sorts when I completed the projects and the course in little more than ten months, given that students usually take at least a year and a half to do the same. Prof. Harrje was sure that Prof. Crocco wouldn't clear my degree so soon, for there was a sense of bewilderment on how I did it so fast. But Prof. Crocco surprised everyone —including me—by giving his nod for clearing my degree. Brocco, an Italian scholar doing a PhD for more than seven years under Prof. Crocco, was happy for me and sad for himself. Brocco was not bad at research, but the highest standards Crocco set for this students made it difficult for anyone trying to pass out of the campus without showing at least some flashes of brilliance. 'The professor,' Brocco told me about Crocco, 'would allow anyone to get a degree, but not an Italian.'

Technically speaking, with Crocco's approval, I was ready to leave the campus with the degree. But Prof. Bill Sirignano, another faculty, wouldn't yield, citing that the ten-and-a-half month within which I completed the